

Distance Regulation in Families

Distance regulation

- One of the family tasks is to regulate and manage emotional distance between family members and subsystems.
- **Internal boundaries** (invisible barriers)
 - *Unspoken rules about what is appropriate and acceptable degree of contact between family members*
 - *Determine* who is involved in an interaction, what roles each person has, how much information is shared, and what degree of emotional closeness or distance is appropriate
- **The goal of a family system** is to maintain a healthy level of appropriate distance and connection between family members

Three Patterns of Internal Boundaries

- Internal boundaries are described along a continuum

Diffuse	Clear	Rigid
Boundaries are overly permeable; roles and emotional responsibilities blur	Roles, authority, privacy, and participation are understandable but flexible	Boundaries are overly closed; access, support, and communication are restricted
A mother repeatedly confides marital distress to her teenage daughter and expects her to provide emotional support	Parents lead parenting decisions, hear children's views, and maintain appropriate parent–child closeness	Parents make all decisions and do not allow children to share their ideas.

Differentiation (Murray Bowen)

- The capacity to maintain a clear sense of **autonomy** (one's own thoughts, values, and choices) while remaining **emotionally connected** to important others—especially under relational stress.
- **Staying connected to others without losing oneself**, and being able to regulate one's own emotions without being overwhelmed by others' anxiety.

Two Markers of- differentiation

1) Degree of emotional connection and dependence

- Need for approval, closeness, and emotional support
- To what extent are the person's emotions and functioning tied to the presence, approval, or reactions of others?

Extremely high emotional connection and dependence

- Strong need for validation, reassurance, or acceptance.
- Anxiety or distress when separated from significant others.
- Difficulty making independent decisions.
- May adapt self excessively to avoid conflict or rejection.

Moderate emotional connection and dependence

- Comfortable being emotionally close but not *needing* it to feel secure.
- Can tolerate temporary distance or disagreement without panic.
- Makes independent choices while staying connected.

2) Emotional Reactivity

- the tendency to respond to situations or relationships with **automatic, intense emotional responses** rather than with calm, thoughtful reflection.
- reflects how much a person's functioning is governed by feelings (anxiety, anger, fear, guilt, etc.) rather than by well-considered principles or reason.

Extremely high emotional reactivity

- Easily upset, anxious, or defensive in relationships.
- Quick to overreact or withdraw when tension arises.
- Difficult to separate own emotions from those of others.
- Often manifests in *fight, flight, or freeze* responses during family or couple conflict.

Lower emotional reactivity (a marker of higher differentiation)

- Ability to stay calm and thoughtful, even when others are distressed.
- Can listen without overidentifying or shutting down.
- Responds flexibly instead of reflexively.

Lack of Differentiation in a Family System : Two Types of Family Fusion

	Type 1: Low tolerance for individuality (ENMESHED)	Type 2: Low tolerance for intimacy (DISENGAGED)
Characteristics	• "emotionally stuck together" • Views individuality as disloyal and threatening to the family's collective oneness • Demands conformity and compliance at any cost	• Communicate little respect, regard, and concern for individual family members • Family members' desire for autonomy is permitted • Their needs for support and intimacy are not met
Consequences for individuation	• Interferes with the abilities of the individual to express their needs for autonomy and individuality.	• Fosters emotional reactivity rather than emotional relatedness • Individuals may be preoccupied with seeking the approval of others that they lacked in the family of origin. • It may interfere with forming a mature relationship with others

Family fusion (Enmeshment)

- A condition where family members are so connected to the family system that it interferes with their ability to manage their own lives.
- Low tolerance for **individuality**; **high tolerance for conformity**
- Not an optimal family condition where healthy individuation can occur
- Often the enmeshed family system uses negative strategies (e.g., control attempts, sympathy, intimidation, coercion, *inducing guilt*) to keep family members connected.
- Family fusion results in a family atmosphere where anxiety, hostility, and tension are common (may not be outwardly shown).

Well-differentiated family system

- family members act in appropriately independent and autonomous ways
- Emotionally connected and intimate in healthy ways
- Family members respect the rights of others
- The desire for privacy is honored
- Individuals are viewed as having the right to think, feel, and act independently of other family members

Individuation as an ongoing developmental process

- Each individual must successfully balance **autonomy** (self as individual) and **interdependence** (self as related to other) in an age-appropriate manner, over the life course
- Early infancy
 - Symbiotic, fused attachment between the caregiver and the baby
 - Asymmetrical, dependent
- Childhood
 - Parent-child relationship becomes more symmetrical

Individuation as an ongoing developmental process

- P-C relationship in adolescence
 - Greater autonomy than childhood but still dependent functionally, psychologically, and financially
- Young adulthood
 - Young adults become more capable of managing their own personal affairs with less help or interference from their parents
 - Make decisions and act without worrying about what our family will say or think
 - Take control of their own lives while remaining intimately connected to family and others

- When a family system is well differentiated, it's easier for an individual to individuate and differentiate.
- How families regulate distance between (1) autonomy/individuality and (2) intimacy/togetherness) is determined by its intergenerational legacy.
 - Parents who are well differentiated are more likely to establish patterns within the family that facilitate differentiation
 - Parents' own unresolved differentiation often results in *subconscious* attempts to reenact unresolved conflicts in their family of origin.

Possible Consequences of Lower Differentiation

- Some stay fused with the family, allowing the family to control their identities
- Others rebel, separating from the family and reactively choose an identity that clearly distinguishes the self from the family
- Some may behave in ways that enable them to appear as if they are controlling their individuality, but they may also remain psychologically dependent on the family at the same time.

흔한 남자의 특별한 이름

나의 아저씨



3월 21일 [수] 밤 9시 10분

tvN 드라마

나의 아저씨

3월 21일 [수] tvN 첫 방송
매주 [수목] 밤 9시 30분



Small Group Talk

- How differentiated is this family?
- How do internal boundaries look in this family?
- What are the reasons for your answer?

Results of family enmeshment

Children lose his/her ability:

- To think for him/herself (i.e., lack of autonomy)
- To solve difficult problems of life effectively (because they tend to be emotionally driven and reactive)
- To make good decisions
- To separate their emotions/feelings from their thoughts
- To regulate their emotions

Other Characteristics of Families with Lack of Differentiation

- Chronic family anxiety
- Emotional triangles

Family chronic anxiety

- **Anxiety:** a negative emotion that includes distress or uneasiness of mind caused by apprehension of danger or misfortune.
- **Long-term** tension or resentment, disappointment in a family system due to unmet important emotional needs → shape interactional patterns in family relationships
 - Solutions:
 - Gain genuine understanding about the person/situation that caused chronic anxiety through perspective-taking
 - forgiveness towards others and self (e.g., it's OK to be inadequate or frail)

Emotional triangles

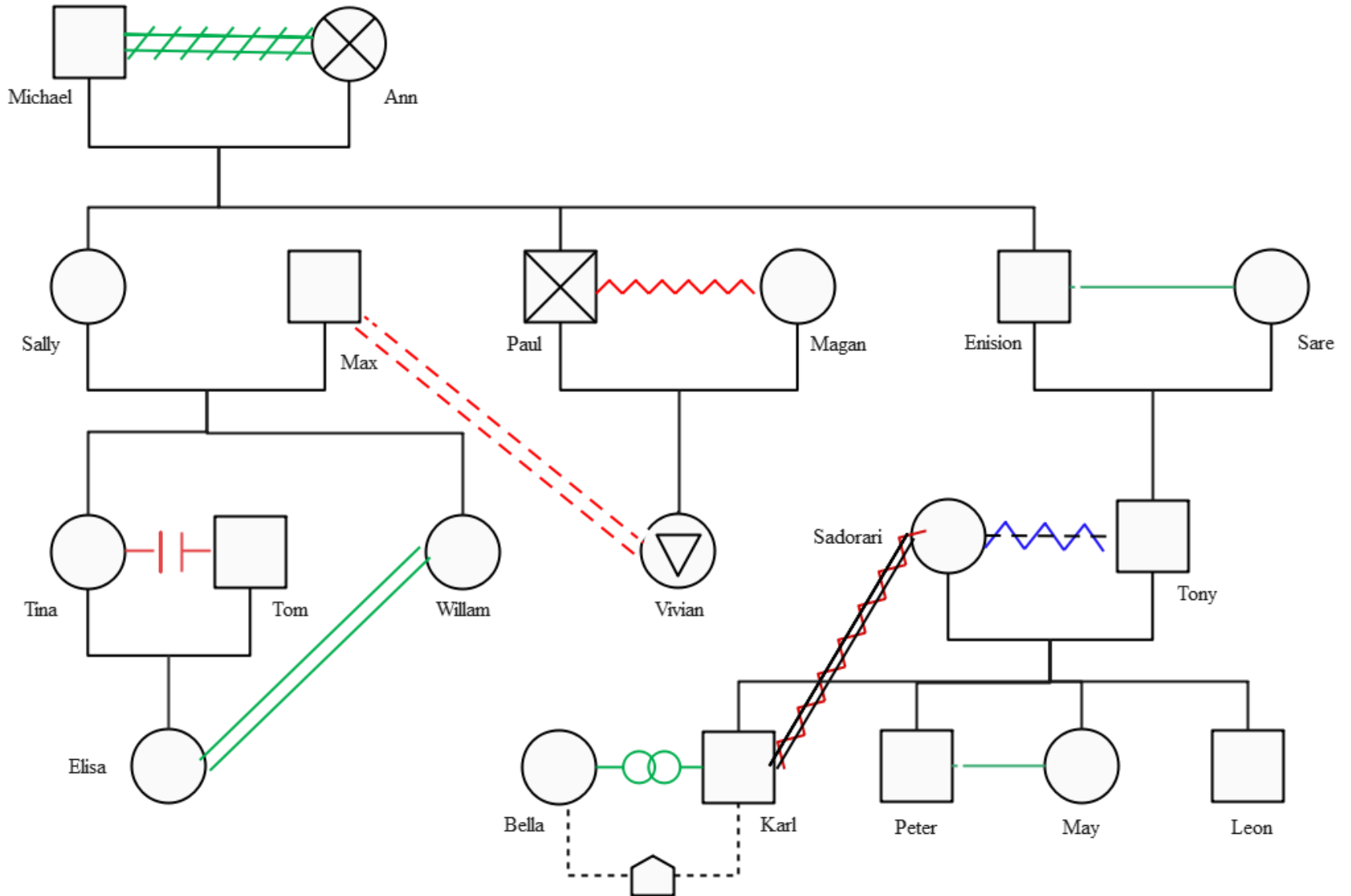
- Occurs when two parts of a family system have an ongoing conflict and they focus on something or someone else as a way of gaining control over the situation or stabilizing their problem
- Can exist in all and any family
- Particularly common experiences in fused families

Coping with family fusion

- (1) Examining interactional processes in your family of origin (e.g., genogram)
- (2) Dealing with invisible loyalties → healthy gratitude
- (3) Undesirable method: emotional cut-off

(1) Using a genogram

- Identify patterns of fusion in family relationships, relational cycles, reactions, conflict, and etc.
- Use the insights gained by examining these patterns in one's family system to not repeat it in one's own family later.



What is invisible loyalty?

(Ivan Boszormenyi-Nagy, 1974)

- an often unspoken—and sometimes unconscious—commitment to one's family of origin.
- It binds a person to inherited expectations, sacrifices, and relational obligations across generations, even when acting on those loyalties is personally costly or appears irrational

Examples of Invisible Loyalty

- A child raised by a single mother may feel that they must become highly successful because their mother sacrificed so much for them.
- Even if the mother never says this directly, the child may believe that failure would waste the mother's sacrifice or betray her.
- This is an unspoken, often unconscious sense of obligation that shapes a person's life choices across generations.
- **Healthy gratitude** vs. invisible loyalty

Invisible Loyalty in Enmeshed Families

- The child may become highly sensitive to the mother's loneliness, financial insecurity, and stories of sacrifice.
- The child may feel, "If I move far away or put my own needs first, I am abandoning my mother," or "I must succeed in order to repay my mother for everything she has done."
- As a result, the child may prioritize the mother's needs and emotions over their own career choices, romantic relationships or marriage, place of residence, and etc.

(4) emotional cut-off

- Undesirable method for coping with fusion
- People may stop interacting with their family in attempts to deny fusion rather than resolve it
 - Remember the principle of intergenerational transmission!
- Some may choose to move away but still remain emotionally fused